starts to get fat, you know there's a bottleneck somewhere in your integration.

3.1.4. Lead time

Lead time is the amount of time between when a task is started and when it is completed. Teams that practice Kanban focus on throughput, and as a result they usually put a heavy emphasis on lead time; the faster they can move tasks through the pipes, the better throughput they can achieve. Some Scrum teams use lead time as well as velocity because the two metrics tell you different things; velocity tells you how much your team can get done in relation to what they think they can get done, and lead time tells you how long it takes to get things done.

The problem with lead time alone is that often teams don't pay close attention to what composes it. Lead time includes creating a task, defining it, working on it, testing it, and releasing it. If you can't decompose it, then it's hard to figure out how to improve it. We'll explore decomposing lead time in later chapters.

For teams that are simply receiving small tickets and pushing them through the system, lead time is a good indicator of how efficient the team can be. But if you have a team that has ownership of the product they're building and is vested in the design of that product, you usually don't have such a simple delivery mechanism. In fact, with the state of automation you could even argue that if your tasks are so small that you don't have to estimate them, then maybe you don't need a human to do them.

Lead time becomes a very valuable metric if you're practicing CD and can measure all of the parts of your delivery process to find efficiencies. It's a great high-level efficiency indicator of the overall process your team follows.

3.1.5. Bug counts